

DragonCandy — What We Need: Developers, Product Manager, Designer

Safe to forward. This document contains no salary or budget information. Send it to candidates, recruiters and development agencies as-is.

Written 2026-08-20 by Damon "Dame" Williams, co-founder & CTO. Questions: Dame (product and technical) or Adrian Vella (sourcing).

In one paragraph

DragonCandy is a live marketplace that connects businesses with content creators. A restaurant gets a social media team without hiring one. A creator gets real paid work instead of chasing gig apps. Our built-in AI, **Donny**, does the busywork in between — writing campaigns, matching people, scheduling and publishing posts. The product is built and working. One person built it. We are hiring the team that takes it from here.

1. What we're building

A three-sided marketplace with an AI assistant running through the middle of it.

Who uses it	What they get
Business (restaurants first)	A social media team, without hiring one
Creator	Real partnerships and reliable payment
Brand / Sponsor	Local reach through real local creators

It is a customer-facing web app at **dragoncandy.com**, plus an iPhone app that is already running on a real device.

Our guiding rule: less typing = more margin. Every main task should take fewer than ten keystrokes. We prefer voice, then camera, then pasting a link, then tapping a button. Typing is the last resort.

2. What it's built with

This is the architecture section. It is written plainly on purpose — please read it before proposing people, because it is not the stack most agencies assume.

Layer	What we use
Front end	React 18, TypeScript (strict mode), Vite, Tailwind CSS, shadcn/ui
Back end	Supabase — PostgreSQL database, authentication, file storage, realtime
Backend functions	98 small Deno/TypeScript functions running on Supabase Edge Functions
Database	PostgreSQL, with Row Level Security — the database itself decides who can read which row
Payments	Stripe Connect (escrow, 80/20 splits, creator payouts). Currently in test mode
AI	Anthropic Claude for generation, OpenAI for embeddings. All server-side, metered, capped
Phone app	Capacitor — wraps the web app into a real iPhone app
Hosting	Vercel (front end and previews)
Cloud	See below — this answer is important
Code launches	Git branch → pull request → automated checks → preview site → human approves → live

About "cloud"

We do not operate a cloud account, and this is deliberate.

Supabase's managed platform runs exclusively on **AWS**, and Vercel's functions run on **AWS** too. So DragonCandy is already on AWS — we simply do not manage it ourselves. There is no VPC to configure, no Kubernetes cluster, no Terraform, no ECS, no load balancers.

What this means for you: we are not looking for a cloud infrastructure engineer or a DevOps specialist, and a candidate whose main strength is AWS architecture is a poor fit here. We need people who are strong at **application code and PostgreSQL**. Infrastructure work at our stage is two clicks in a dashboard.

We have no plan to migrate to a self-managed cloud. If we ever do, it will be because we crossed a specific measured threshold, not because of a preference.

Where the work is actually hard

Most developers handle the screens fine. Three things are genuinely difficult here, and they are where the seniority requirement comes from:

1. **Database permissions.** Every query must be correct for a business, a creator and a brand. Get it wrong and one customer sees another customer's private data. We have found and fixed several of these already.
2. **Money.** Escrow, splits, payouts, refunds, disputes. Paying a creator twice is bad. Not paying them is worse. Both must be impossible.

3. **The 98 backend functions.** Each must check who is calling it and what they are allowed to touch. Being logged in is not the same as being allowed.

How big it is

Source files	1,186
Screens	92
Backend functions	98
Database changes applied	389
Automated tests	2,492

This is a large, real codebase. It is not a prototype, and nobody is going to rewrite it.

3. Who we need

Four people, in two waves.

Role	Level	Starts	Where
Product Manager	Mid-senior	Wave 1	US, or US working hours
UX / Product Designer	Mid-senior	Wave 1	Europe fine
Senior Developer	Senior — owns the code	Wave 2 (+30 days)	Anywhere, hours permitting
Mid-Level Developer	Mid	Wave 2 (+30 days)	Europe fine

The shape matters more than the number. One senior developer owns the codebase. Everyone else works around that person. We would rather have one genuinely senior engineer than two average ones.

The first 90 days are an audit, not a build. The product manager and designer start by going through every screen for all three types of user and writing down what is broken, confusing or unfinished. That list becomes the work. The developers join 30 days later and start on a real backlog instead of a blank page.

Full role descriptions are separate documents — one per role.

4. What every technical hire must have

Required

- **Strong React and TypeScript.** TypeScript strict mode, not "I've used TypeScript."
- **Real PostgreSQL depth.** Not just writing queries — understanding permissions, indexes and transactions. Our security lives in the database.

- **Experience on a customer-facing product.** Something real people used and paid for.
- **Fluency with AI coding assistants — specifically Claude Code, Claude Cowork and OpenAI Codex.** This is a hard requirement, not a preference. See below.
- **The judgment to work inside a large existing codebase** rather than wanting to rebuild it.

Why the AI requirement is not negotiable

Most of this product was built with AI assistance, and our review process depends on it. Every branch runs an automated **OpenAI Codex** review before a human is allowed to approve it. A second AI model reviews before that. This is not a preference we are expressing — it is how code gets merged here.

A developer who will not use these tools cannot pass our pipeline, and will be slower here than they were at their last job. We would rather say this clearly up front than discover it in week three.

Bonus: experience with Cursor.

Nice to have

- Stripe or comparable payments experience
- Shipping an app to the Apple App Store
- Marketplace or two-sided platform experience

On years of experience

Roughly **7+ years for the senior role** and **3+ for the mid-level role**. We treat years as a weak signal. The real filter is the paid trial described below — two weeks of actual work tells us more than a CV and an interview combined.

On native mobile

We do not need a native iOS or Android developer. Capacitor wraps our existing web app into a real iPhone app, so the phone app is built from the same React code. Someone who has shipped through App Store review before is a bonus, not a requirement.

5. Working hours

	Central European	US Eastern
Working day	12:00 – 18:00	06:00 – 12:00
Meetings and calls	13:00 – 17:00	07:00 – 11:00

Central Europe is **6 hours ahead of US Eastern, all year round**.

That gives about **three hours of live overlap** with the US every day, deliberately placed in the European afternoon so nobody is working late at night. Dame starts his day at 06:00 US Eastern to meet it.

Outside those hours, we work asynchronously and in writing. We are not asking anyone in Europe to work American evenings.

6. Start date, length, and extending

Start	Target Q4 2026. Gated on funding closing — Joe Castelo is raising now.
Order	Product manager and designer first. Developers 30 days later.
Trial	Every hire begins with a paid two-week trial on a real ticket from the audit backlog. Paid at full rate.
Initial term	6 months after a successful trial.
Extension	Yes — extend, or convert to permanent. Six months is a starting point, not a ceiling.

The trial applies to development agencies too. It is the only fair way to find out whether we get the person we met in the pitch. We pay for it properly.

7. Rate

Deliberately not in this document, so that it stays forwardable.

We have budgeted by region and know what we intend to pay. **Please send your rate or salary expectation with the candidate** and we will tell you straight away whether we are in the same range. We would rather find that out in the first email than the third call.

8. Why this is a good job

Said honestly, because senior people can tell when it isn't:

- **You will own something real.** A working product with actual users, not a greenfield project that may never launch.
- **The engineering practice is unusually good for a company this size.** Automated checks, preview environments for every change, two independent AI reviews before a human approves, and a written knowledge base the AI assistant itself reads from.
- **Genuinely hard problems.** Database-level multi-tenant security and real money movement, not another CRUD dashboard.
- **You are early.** We are pre-revenue by choice, with the product built. If it grows, the people who joined at this point grow with it.
- **Small team, no theatre.** Two-week cycles, written updates, minimal meetings. The pipeline enforces quality, not process.

We are also straightforward about the risk: no paying customers yet, and no launch date set. Anyone joining should know that.

9. What we need back from you

For agencies and recruiters, so we can move quickly:

1. **Named individuals, not a pool.** We want to meet the person who would actually do the work.
2. **A CV plus something they built** that a real person used.
3. **Their rate expectation**, up front.
4. **Confirmation they can work 12:00–18:00 Central European time.**
5. **Confirmation they use Claude Code, Claude Cowork or Codex daily** — and honesty if they don't.
6. **Availability for a paid two-week trial** before any longer commitment.